survived. So, we could be dealing with a culture that coincides with the early Harappan age. I know that not all scholars would agree with this—but it is important to keep this possibility in mind.

CAN ONE RECONCILE THE TWO ACCOUNTS?

The Harappan civilization and the Rig Veda coincide on many things—their time frames, their geography, the Bronze Age technology and even on the existence of the Saraswati river. Were they the same people? Combined with the genetic data discussed in the earlier chapter, it would seem that we are dealing with a population and culture that has continuously inhabited the subcontinent for a very long time. For some, especially archaeologists like B.B. Lal, the matter is settled. However, there are many scholars who remain sceptical. Let us look at many of the arguments usually put forward against identifying the Harappans with the Rig Vedic people. We will start with the weaker arguments and make our way to the more serious ones.

One of the oldest arguments is that the Rig Vedic people were nomads from Central Asia who could not have built the sophisticated cities of the Indus Valley. This is why, so the argument goes, the Rig Veda shows little knowledge of India's geography beyond the North West. This is a spurious argument because the Rig Veda neither mentions an invasion nor does it show any knowledge of Central Asia. All we can garner from the text is that these people were living in the area that corresponds roughly to modern Haryana, western Uttar Pradesh and Punjab (including Pakistani Punjab). They also knew about the Himalayas in the north, the seas in the south, the Ganga to the east and eastern Afghanistan to the west. It is entirely possible that they may have known about South India and/or Central Asia but the text tells us nothing about this.

Furthermore, the Rig Vedic people are clearly aware of settled agriculture and of cities—both inhabited by themselves and those inhabited by their enemies. They are not wild nomads from the Steppes as has been suggested. Admittedly, the Rig Veda does not obviously reflect the Harappan obsession